

Interview Protocol for: Investigating the Role of AI in Emergency Management: Use Cases, Challenges, and Opportunities

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We provide the interview protocol for our study on emergency managers (EMs) [1]. This protocol, along with other details about the interview study, is also described in Appendix D and Appendix E of the main paper.

1 Interview Script

Background

Let's start with your work background.

- (1) In a few sentences, can you please describe your work experience related to emergency management?
- (2) Roughly how many disaster response efforts have you participated in?
- (3) What types of disaster events have you responded to?
- (4) How would you describe your current position and job responsibilities?
- (5) *[If not answered in 4]* What is your typical role in disaster response efforts?
- (6) *[If indicated in their form response that they use AI in their job]* Can you please describe how you use AI in your job?

Decision-making Scenarios

Now that I have a better understanding of your job functions, I'd love to learn more about specific decisions you make in the context of your job.

- (7) Can you please describe what you consider to be a critical decision in emergency management that you have been a part of?
 - a. In that scenario, can you please tell me about the decision process?
 - b. What was your role in the process?
 - c. What data or factors did you consider when making your decision?
 - d. What information were you given during that scenario?
 - e. What did you know about the situation before you were presented with this decision scenario?

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- f. What did you know about the stakeholders (people who will receive the resource) before you were presented with this decision scenario?
- g. Did you decide in a team or on your own?
- h. Once you made a decision, can you run me through what happens next?
- i. Who or what was responsible for the execution of the next steps?

Decision-making Scenarios with Resource Constraints

- (8) Have you ever encountered a situation where the number of requests for a resource exceeded the resources available?
 - a. In that scenario, can you please tell me about your decision process for allocating resources?
 - b. What data or factors did you consider when making your decision?
 - c. What information were you given during that scenario?
 - d. What did you know about the situation before you were presented with this decision scenario?
 - e. What did you know about the stakeholders (people who will receive the resource) before you were presented with this decision scenario?
 - f. Did you decide in a team or on your own?
 - g. Once you made a decision, can you run me through how the resources were allocated?
 - i. *[If not covered]* Who or what was responsible for the distribution of resources?
- (9) *[If time permits]* Have you encountered the same type of resource decision where *[add details based on their previous description]* in other disaster events?
 - a. Can you tell me more about the similarities between those situations?
 - b. Can you tell me more about the differences between those situations?
- (10) *[If time permits]* Have you encountered different situations with a different type of limited resources and high demand? Can you please describe them for me?

Protective Actions Decision-making Scenarios

- (11) Have you participated in making decisions about protective measures (protective actions) before a forecasted disaster?
 - a. What type of protective measures were involved?
 - b. What population was affected?
 - c. In that scenario, can you please tell me about the decision process?
 - d. What data or factors did you consider when making your decision?
 - e. What information were you given during that scenario?
 - f. What did you know about the situation before you were presented with this decision scenario?
 - g. What did you know about the stakeholders (people who are affected by the protective measures) before you were presented with this decision scenario?
 - h. Did you decide in a team or on your own?
 - i. Once you made a decision, can you walk me through how the protective measures were executed?
 - i. *[If not covered]* Who or what was responsible for executing the protective measures?
- (12) *[If not covered in previous question(s)]* Have you participated in making decisions about evacuation plans before a forecasted disaster?

- a. What type of evacuation plans were involved?
 - b. What population was involved?
 - c. In that scenario, can you please tell me about the decision process?
 - d. What data or factors did you consider when making your decision?
 - e. What information were you given during that scenario?
 - f. What did you know about the situation before you were presented with this decision scenario?
 - g. What did you know about the stakeholders (people who are affected by the protective measures) before you were presented with this decision scenario?
 - h. Did you make a decision in a team or on your own?
 - i. Once you made a decision, can you walk me through how the evacuation measures were executed?
 - i. *[If not covered]* Who or what was responsible for executing the evacuation measures?
- (13) *[If not covered in previous question(s)]* Have you participated in making decisions about the pre-positioning of resources before a forecasted disaster?
- a. In that scenario, can you please tell me about your decision process as to how to decide where to pre-position resources?
 - b. *[If not covered]* Did you make use of logistic staging areas?
 - i. Can you tell me more about logistic staging areas?
 - c. What data or factors did you consider when making your decision?
 - d. What information were you given during that scenario?
 - e. What did you know about the situation before you were presented with this decision scenario?
 - f. What did you know about the stakeholders (people who will receive the resource) before you were presented with this decision scenario?
 - g. Did you decide in a team or on your own?
 - h. Once you made a decision, can you run me through how the resources were pre-positioned?
 - i. Who or what was responsible for the pre-positioning of resources?

Opportunities to Improve Decision-making Scenarios

Thank you so much for your detailed responses! Now that we've discussed some interesting decision scenarios, I'm curious about your perspective on how things could be done better. Please answer the following questions keeping in mind the decision scenarios we talked about before.

- (14) In the scenarios we discussed before, how effective was the amount of information/general setup of the process for you in making your decision? Why or why not?
- (15) In any of the scenarios we discussed before, what do you think could help improve the decision making process?
- (16) Now, let's focus on technology—where do you think AI technology could help improve your decision making process?
- (17) *[If they mentioned using AI at job in pre-interview survey]* How would you improve the AI you already use in your job?

Disaster Recovery Center Planning

Now, we're going to shift our focus to disaster recovery. We're interested in physical locations set up after a natural disaster where survivors can learn about financial assistance programs and get help applying for assistance.

(18) What term do you use to describe such locations?

If they ask for clarification about what we mean, mention these may be called Disaster Recovery Centers or Multi-agency resource centers (MARCs)

(19) Have you been involved in planning or supporting the placement of these “disaster recovery centers”¹?

(20) *[if 19 is yes]* How long after a typical natural disaster are you/your department involved in administering “disaster recovery centers”?

(21) Have you been directly involved in planning/placement of “disaster recovery centers”?

(22) What plans are there for placement of “disaster recovery centers” before a disaster?

(23) What factors do you/your team consider when deciding locations of these “disaster recovery centers”?

(24) To staff and/or maintain these “disaster recovery centers”, are there partnerships worked out with local organizations and businesses worked out beforehand? How about with larger nonprofits?

(25) After a disaster, how is information about “disaster recovery centers” shared with survivors?

(26) *[If not covered in previous question(s)]* Does this information sharing include providing information to survivors in person?

Conclusion

- Before we wrap up, do you have any final thoughts about what we discussed today that you would like to share or address?
- Do you have any questions for me?

Thank you so much for your time.

References

- [1] Samsara Foubert, Minjung Park, Kanad Pardeshi, Thomas Manzini, Robert McDaniel, David Merrick, Robin Murphy, Aarti Singh, and Hoda Heidari. 2026. Investigating the Role of AI in Emergency Management: Use Cases, Challenges, and Opportunities. In *Proceedings of the 2026 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (FAcCT '26)*. Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, 2055–2091. doi:10.1145/3805689.3812279

¹From now on, we use “disaster recovery centers” as a placeholder for the term they identified in their response to #18